

BUYER'S GUIDE

Buying Your Home, Step by Step

What to expect from the first showing to the day you get the keys.

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PART 1

Getting Ready to Buy

Step one: get pre-qualified

Before we look at homes, talk to a lender and get pre-qualified. That's a quick check of how much you can borrow. It's enough to start looking with me.

Before you make an offer, it's best to take the next step and get pre-approved. That takes more paperwork, but sellers take it more seriously.

Choosing a lender

You're free to use any lender you like. If you'd like a recommendation, I've worked with Ethan Dean for some time. He takes good care of his clients. You can call or text him at 864-380-8963.



What you'll need besides the down payment

Your lender will give you a Loan Estimate. It shows your rate, your monthly payment, and your closing costs. Ask questions until it makes sense.

Plan for these, too

- **Earnest money.** Your good-faith deposit when you make an offer. More on that in Part 3.
- **Inspections.** You pay the inspector, usually at the inspection.
- **The appraisal.** Your lender orders it. It's usually part of your closing costs.
- **Homeowners insurance.** Your lender will need proof of it before closing. It's smart to get quotes early.

Step two: the buyer agreement

Before I can show you any home, we sign a buyer agreement. It's the form that lets me work for you as your agent.

- It has to be signed before the first showing.
- You choose how long it lasts.
- A short term works like a trial for both of us.

> **My fee**
> Our agreement spells out my fee. I always ask the seller to pay it first. Whatever the seller pays counts toward what you'd owe.

I'll send you a short guide that explains the agreement in more detail.

Make a wish list

Before we start, write down what you need and what you'd like. Keep them separate.

- **Needs:** the number of bedrooms, the school area, how far you'll drive to work.
- **Wants:** a garage, a big yard, an updated kitchen.

Few homes have everything. A clear list helps us find the one that has what matters most.



PART 2

Finding Your Home

Getting listings

I'll set you up with regular emails of homes that match what you're looking for. You'll probably also browse Zillow and other sites on your own. That's great. Between the two, we won't miss much.

When you see one you like

When you find homes you like, send them to me. We'll see a few in one trip. Seeing them side by side makes it easier to compare.

Keeping track

I'll text you a link you can open on your phone. As we tour, you can jot notes on each home, so they don't all blur together by the end of the day.



What to look at on a showing

Paint, carpet, and furniture are easy to change. Look past them. Pay closer attention to things that are hard or costly to change:

- The location and the street.
- The layout, and how the rooms flow.
- The roof, windows, and heating and cooling, and how old they are.
- Signs of water: stains on ceilings, a musty smell, soft spots in the floor.

Take your time. Open closets and cabinets. It's your visit.



PART 3

From Offer to Closing

Deciding what to offer

Before we write an offer, I'll show you what similar homes nearby have sold for. Then we'll decide on a price, and whether to ask the seller to help with your closing costs or my fee.

What the seller will tell you

In South Carolina, the seller fills out a disclosure form about the home's condition. You'll get it before you sign a contract. Read it closely. It's a good guide for what to check during your inspection.

Earnest money

Earnest money is your good-faith deposit. It's usually at least $3,000 to $5,000. A bigger deposit shows the seller you're serious. It's applied toward your purchase at closing.



The due diligence period

During due diligence, you can back out for any reason. The contract can set a fee you'd owe the seller if you do. It's often small. We'll talk about it before we write the offer.

After the period ends, you can't back out for those reasons. So we schedule your inspections right away.

Inspections

You're free to choose any home inspector. Most buyers don't have one in mind, so I'm glad to suggest a couple I know.

Expect a long report. An inspector notes everything that isn't perfect, even in a well-kept home. Focus on the big items: roof, structure, plumbing, electrical, and heating and cooling.

A licensed pest company also does a termite inspection, usually around the same time.

Asking for repairs

After the inspection, we can send the seller a list of repairs you'd like. The seller can say yes, say no, or offer something else, like a credit toward your closing costs or a lower price. This has to be settled before due diligence ends. If you and the seller can't agree, you can back out.

The appraisal

I always write offers that depend on the home appraising at your price. I never want you stuck paying more for a home than it's worth.

If the appraisal comes in low, the seller may lower the price, or we can talk it over. If you can't agree, you can back out.

Until closing: no new credit

Until closing, please don't open any new credit. That means no new cards, and no financing for a car or furniture.

Also check with your lender before changing jobs or moving large sums of money. Any of these can delay your loan, or even sink it.

How long until closing?

Most purchases close in about 4 to 6 weeks.

1

Weeks 1 and 2

Inspections, the termite inspection, and the due diligence period. Repair requests get settled.

2

Weeks 2 and 3

The appraisal and your loan. The closing attorney checks that the title is clear.

3

The last week or two

Final loan approval. You set up insurance, utilities, and your move.

4

Closing day

You sign the papers and get the keys.



Closing day

On closing day, we'll start with a final walk-through. We'll make sure the seller has moved out and nothing new has come up. Then we head to the attorney's office.

- Bring your photo ID.
- For your down payment, never trust wiring instructions sent by email. Call the attorney's office first, at a number you already know is real.

> **Then you get the keys. Welcome home.**





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Ready to start looking, or just have a question? Call or text me anytime.

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Principles Before Profits

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